

Session 27: The Purpose of Ezekiel's Temple Vision

Key Takeaways

- Israel and its kings defiled the temple and corrupted the entire land with injustice, idolatry, and violence.
- Presumptuous kings of Judah tried to elevate their own status by making their burial sites next to the temple.
- The symmetry, order, and proper function of the temple vision communicate a message that induces conviction and guilt over these past abuses.
- Whatever role Ezekiel's vision plays in the larger mosaic of biblical theology, we must honor its purpose for Ezekiel and his audience.

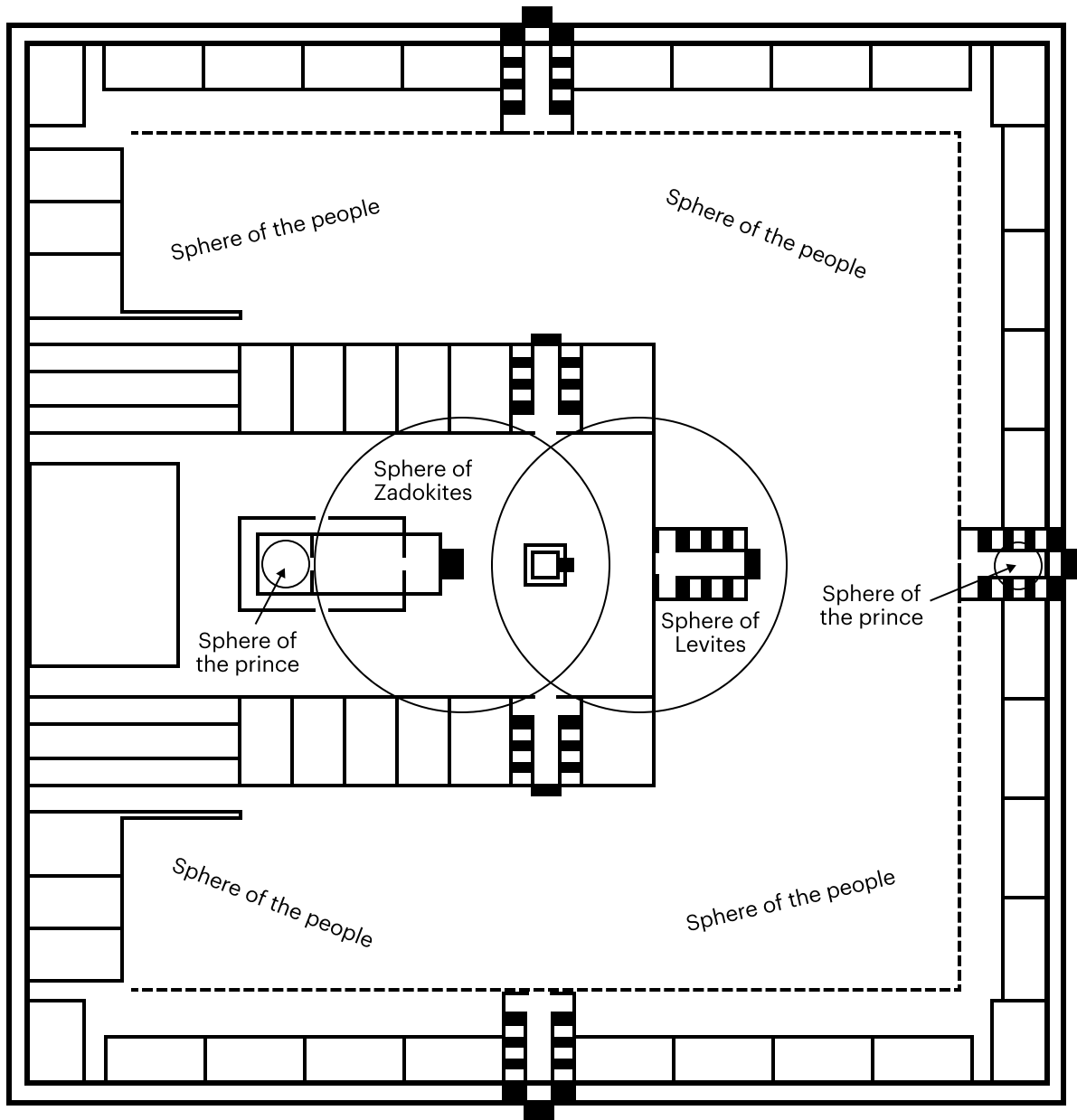
The Three Sacred Zones of Ezekiel 40-48

The nine chapters that make up Ezekiel 40-48 work forward in a sequence that deals with three sacred spaces, scaling larger with each section.

1. The temple and its place within the city
2. The portion alongside the temple and city
3. The land surrounding the temple and the portion

The Temple (Ezek. 40:1-44:31)

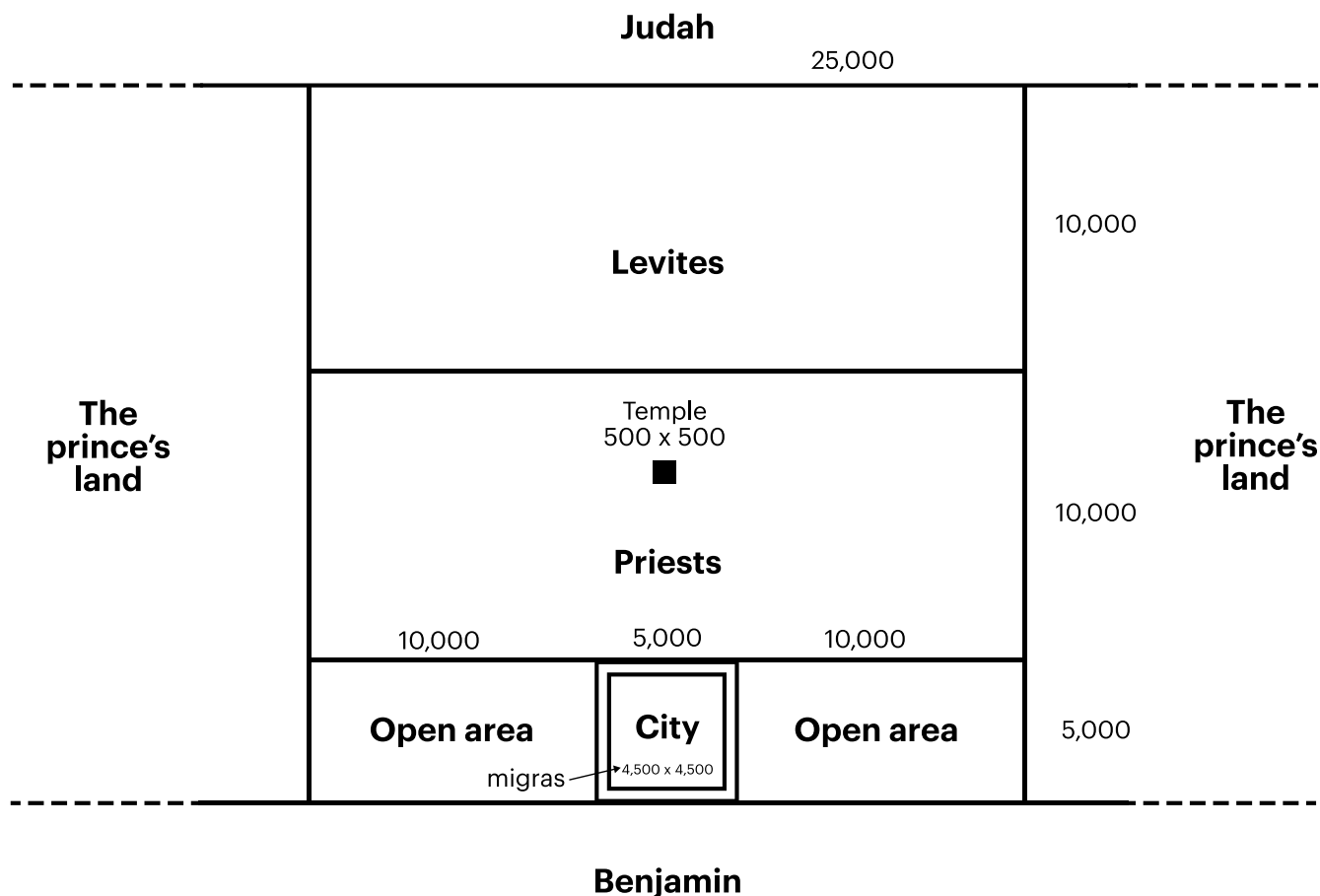
Every part of this section defines the spaces dedicated to the temple, its courts, and the access points into and out of this space. The measurements and design all control access to this space in order to prevent past abuses of the temple.



Ezekiel's Temple Zones. Block, Daniel (1998). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans.

The Portion (Ezek. 45:1-46:24)

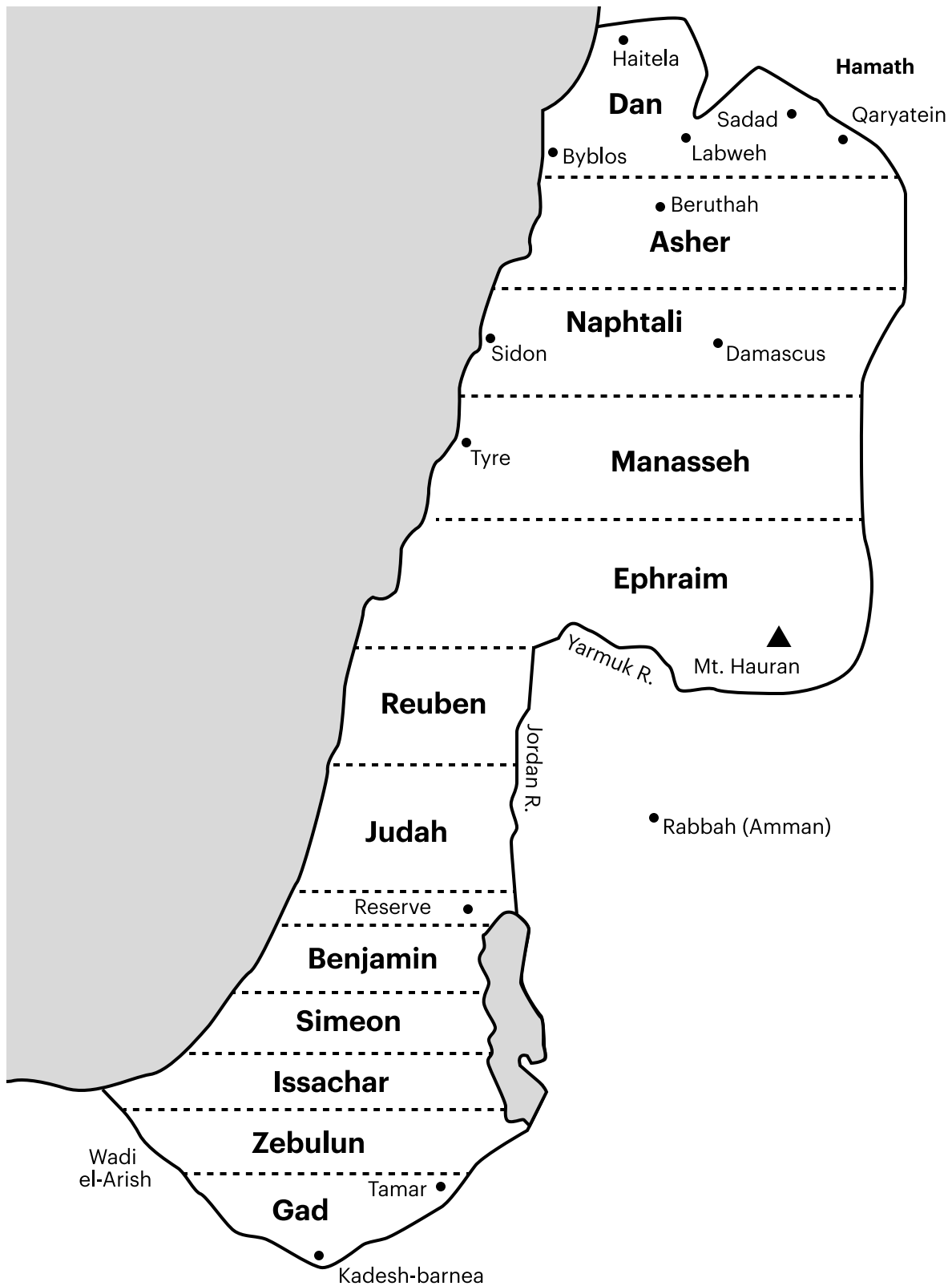
This section separates the temple and the realm of the priests away from both the Levites and the king, and also from the "city," which isn't even called Jerusalem. This spatial reorganization communicates that Yahweh's space is not under the control of the priesthood, but vice-versa. All of Israel's space and institutions are subordinate to and organized around Yahweh.



The Land Around the Temple. Adapted from Block, Daniel (1998). [The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)](#). Eerdmans.

The Land (Ezek. 47:1-48:35)

This organization redistributes the promised land to the classic twelve tribe organization that began in the era of Moses and Joshua, but it's redistributed in a way that totally ignores the land's topography. Ezekiel's organization disregards geographic realism in favor of theological idealism, and his organization distributes the land without recognition of tribal population. Each tribe is given its own historic possession.



The Land of the Twelve Tribes. Adapted from Block, Daniel (1998). [*The Book of Ezekiel, Chapters 25-48 \(The New International Commentary on the Old Testament\)*](#). Eerdmans.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 43:1-11

¹ And he led me to the **gate** ,
the gate facing toward the east ;

A ² and look, **the glory of the Elohim of Israel** was coming from **the way of the east** ,
and his voice was like the sound of many waters,
and the land was lit up by **his glory** ,

³ and it was like the **appearance** of the **vision** which I **saw** ,
B like the **vision** which I **saw** when he came to destroy the city,
and the **visions** were like the **vision** which I **saw** by the river Chebar,
and I fell on my face.

a ⁴ And **the glory of Yahweh** entered into **the house** by **the way of the gate facing east** ,
A' b ⁵ and the Spirit lifted me up,
b' and she brought me into the inner court,
a' and look, **the glory of Yahweh** filled **the house** .

⁶ And I heard one speaking to me from **the house** ,
and a man was standing beside me,

⁷ he said to me,
A "Son of a human,
this is the place of my throne,
and the place of the soles of my feet,
where **I will dwell among the sons of Israel forever** ,

and the house of Israel will not again **make my holy name impure** ,
neither **they** nor **their kings** ,
by **their harlotry** and by **the corpses of their kings** when they die,

B ⁸ by setting their threshold alongside my threshold,
and their door post beside my door post,
with only the wall between me and them,
and they have **made my holy name impure** by their abominations which they have committed,
and I brought them to an end in my anger.

A' ⁹ Now, let them remove **their harlotry** and **the corpses of their kings** far from me,
and **I will dwell among them forever** .

¹⁰ As for you, Son of a human,
declare (דגל) the house to the house of Israel,
so that **they may be ashamed of their iniquities** ,
and so they can measure the proportion/perfection,

¹¹ And **when they are ashamed of all that they have done** ,
a

- a b **the form** of **the house**,
 - c and its design,
 - d and its exits,
 - d' and its entrances,
 - c' and all its **forms** and all its **statutes**,
 - b' and all its **forms** and all its **instructions**,
 - a' make known to them.
- And write before in their eyes,
so that they may observe all **its form** and all its **statutes**,
and engage them.

- a ¹² This is **the instruction** of **the house** on the top of the mountain:
- b its entire boundary all around will be most holy;
- a' look, this is **the instruction** of the house."

Ezekiel 43:1-11. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Return of the King (Ezek. 43:1-5)

This opening scene describes the reversal of Yahweh's abandonment of the temple in chapters 8-11 because of Israel's idolatry and covenant infidelity. There have been important future anticipations of this return throughout Ezekiel's oracles (see [Ezek. 20:40-43](#); [37:26-28](#)), but this is the culmination of the initial visions of divine glory first in Babylon (chapters 1-3), then in leaving the temple (chapters 8-11), and now its return.

Notice the explicit recall of the previous visions from chapters 1-3 ("like the vision I saw by the river Khebar") and from chapters 8-11 ("like the vision I saw when it came to destroy the city").

Yahweh's Throne Purified From Past Abuse (Ezek. 43:6-9)

Notice that Yahweh's return to the temple is described in language that recalls the promise of a restored sanctuary from [Ezekiel 37:26-28](#), and both texts are themselves dependent on the description of the wilderness tabernacle from [Exodus 25](#), and also on the conception of the holy of holies as a divine throne, an idea expressed in Isaiah ([6:1-3](#) and [66:1-2](#)) and the Psalms ([11:4](#), [103:19](#)).

Ezekiel 43:7a NASB

He said to me, "Son of man, this is **the place of my throne** and **the place of the soles of my feet**, where **I will dwell among the sons of Israel forever**.

Ezekiel 37:26-28 NASB

²⁶ ... And I will place them and multiply them, and will set **my sanctuary in their midst forever**. ²⁷ **My dwelling place also will be with them**; and I will be their God, and they will be my people. ²⁸ And the nations will know that I am the Lord who sanctifies Israel, when **my sanctuary is in their midst forever**.

Isaiah 6:1 NASB*

In the year of King Uzziah's death I saw **Yahweh sitting on a throne**, lofty and exalted, with the train of his robe filling the temple.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 66:1-2a NASB*

¹ Thus says Yahweh, "**The skies are my throne and the land is my footstool**. Where then is a house you could build for me? And where is a place that I may rest? ² "For my hand made all these things, thus all these things came into being," declares the LORD.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 11:4 NASB*

Yahweh is in his holy temple; **Yahweh's throne is in the skies**

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 103:19 NASB*

Yahweh has established **his throne in the skies**, and his sovereignty rules over all.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 132:7-8 NASB*

⁷ Let us go into his dwelling place; let us worship at **his footstool**. ⁸ Arise, O Yahweh, to **your resting place**, you and the ark of your strength.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The newness of Yahweh's purified throne is set in contrast to a long history of its abuse and defilement, specifically by the kings of Judah. Three specific abuses are highlighted.

Royal Memorials

At first glance, the phrase "by the corpses of their kings when they die" appears to describe the burial of Judah's kings near the temple grounds. This is odd, however, because most of the kings of Judah are said to have been buried down the southern hill from the temple mount in the city of David (see [1 Kgs. 2:10](#) and the rest of the Kings scroll). There are two kings, however, notorious ones for Ezekiel, who were said to have been buried in a royal palace garden, and this could have been near or adjacent to the temple.

2 Kings 21:18 NASB

And Manasseh slept with his fathers and was **buried in the garden of his own house, in the garden of Uzza**, and Amon his son became king in his place.

2 Kings 21:26 NASB

[Amon, son of Manasseh] was **buried in his grave in the garden of Uzza**, and Josiah his son became king in his place.

Another possibility is that the Hebrew phrase “when they die” (במותם) should be interpreted to mean “their ritual pillars” (במותם, often rendered “high places”), and so this would refer to stone memorial pillars that were placed in the royal palace next to the temple. These pillars were often used in cults of the dead ancestors, where offerings were made and the presence of the ancestors could be channelled and accessed (see the hints of this practice described in [Isa. 8:18-20](#)).

Either way, the point is that Israel’s kings placed their dead bodies or memorial statues near the temple, and the corpse-impurity or ritual practices were a defilement of God’s holy presence in the temple.

Architectural Usurpation

What does the phrase “by putting their threshold/door beside my threshold/door” mean?

In the narrative about Solomon building the temple, the narrator gives equal attention to Solomon’s efforts to build his own house right next to the temple (see [1 Kgs. 7:1-12](#)).

This could also refer to Manasseh’s construction of altars and shrines to other deities in the temple precincts ([2 Kings 21:5](#)).

The point is clearly that Israel’s kings usurped the temple precincts for their own royal agendas, thus subordinating Yahweh’s holiness to their own aims. But now that Israel’s true king has been enthroned in the center of the land, this will be no more.

Idolatry

Allusions to “their harlotry” and “making my name impure through their abominations” are almost certainly references back to the idolatrous worship profiled back in Ezekiel 8-11.

The Purpose of Ezekiel's Temple Vision

In [Ezekiel 43:10-11](#), Ezekiel is told to “declare” the vision to the exiles, “so that they can measure the proportion.” The word “proportion” is key to understanding the nature of Ezekiel’s vision.

“The proportion” is the Hebrew word *toknit* / תכנית.

This word is incorrectly translated “the plan/pattern” in the NASB, ESV, NRSV, KJV as if the word were a synonym with the similar sound word *tavnit* / תבנית. The NIV offers a translation based on a close study of the word in context.

Ezekiel 43:10 NASB, ESV

... Let them measure **the plan**.

as if from *tavnit*

Ezekiel 43:10 NRSV, KJV

... Let them measure **the pattern** ...

as if from *tavnit*

Ezekiel 43:10 NIV

... Let them consider **its perfection** ...

based on the Hebrew text, *toknit*

What Is a *Toknit* (תכנית)?

The rare Hebrew noun *toknit* / תכנית appears only one other time in the Hebrew Bible, in Ezekiel 28:12.

Ezekiel 28:12 NASB

You were a seal of **perfect proportion (*toknit*)**.

said to the king of Tyre

The meaning “perfect proportion” is based on studying the meaning of this noun's root word, which occurs in the Hebrew verb “to allocate, to assign based on a measure.”

It can refer to an “accurate measure” when someone is weighing amounts in a balance.

1 Samuel 2:3 NASB*

Boast no more so very proudly, do not let arrogance come out of your mouth; for the LORD is a God of knowledge, and with him actions are **fairly measured/weighed**.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Proverbs 16:2 NASB*

All the ways of a man are clean in his own sight, but the LORD **fairly measures/weights** the motives.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Similar idea repeated in [21:2](#) and [24:12](#).

2 Kings 12:11 NASB

They gave the money which was **weighed** out into the hands of those who did the work, who had the oversight of the house of the LORD; and they paid it out to the carpenters and the builders who worked on the house of the LORD;

It can refer to an abstract concept of “perfect measurement” when speaking of justice and fairness.

Ezekiel 18:25 NASB*

Yet you say, "The way of the LORD doesn't **measure up right**." Hear now, O house of Israel! Is it my way that doesn't **measure up right**? Is it not your ways that don't **measure up right**?

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Similar idea repeated in [18:29](#) and [33:17, 20](#).

It can refer to a builder giving perfect proportions to a structure.

Job 28:23-26 NASB*

²³ God understands its way, and he knows its place. ²⁴ For he looks to the ends of the earth and sees everything under the heavens. ²⁵ When he imparted weight to the wind and **perfectly distributed** the waters by measure, ²⁶ when he set a limit for the rain and a course for the thunderbolt.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The verb *tikken* means to apply a just or correct measure in the (a) evaluation of something, or in the (b) creation of something which requires perfect and accurate proportions.

This helps us understand the use of the noun in Ezekiel 28:12, which describes the king of Tyre as a seal of “perfect proportion,” that is, designed symmetrically and with ideal measurements.

This linguistic evidence leads to the conclusion that the NIV and many scholars have come to; in Ezekiel 43:10, the prophet invites the exiles to “measure the perfect proportions” of the temple.

The Perfect Proportions of the Temple

What exactly are the “perfect proportions” of the temple? All of chapters 40-42 have been consumed on the horizontal measurements of the temple complex. The lack of vertical dimensions (except for the outer wall and the gate houses) shows that Ezekiel's vision focuses on the arrangement of space rather than on structures as such.

“If one were to enter through the eastern and most important gate, one would observe a perfect symmetrical design. What one sees to the north is perfectly mirrored by what one sees to the south, while in contrast the views from the northern or southern gates would be asymmetrical ... Even more important are the series of perfect squares in the compound. The entire temple complex is 500 by 500 cubits. The most sacred area of all, the Holy of Holies is a square 20 cubits deep and 20 cubits wide ... The center of the entire compound is the altar, whose upper platform measures 14 by 14 cubits while the base measures 20 by 20 cubits, matching the size of the Holy of Holies ... As one looked from the eastern gate, the symmetrical design would lead the eyes up the center line up to the altar, and then past that up further through the temple doors and into the most holy space ... The shape and size of the entire complex reflects lofty theological and spiritual ideals. Its perfect design is in keeping with the perfection of the divine resident.”

Block, Daniel (2013). “Guarding the Glory of YHWH: Ezekiel's Geography of Sacred Space.” In [Beyond the River Chebar: Studies in Kingship and Eschatology in the Book of Ezekiel](#) (1st ed., pp. 175–196). The Lutterworth Press.

Ezekiel's audience should study the plans of the house, but not in order to build it. There is no command or even a hint that the exiles are to view this as a building program. Rather, when they see the arrangement, form, and proportions of the space, the goal is for them to feel ashamed of all of the ways in the past that they

and their ancestors abused Yahweh's holy space. The rhetorical goal of this visionary plan is to portray the ideal proportions of the true temple in such a way that it will confront the exiles visually and expose how their past wrongs led them to the exile. By exploring the ideal temple, in great detail, Ezekiel's account exposes to the exiles just how corrupted the Jerusalem temple has become.

The goal of this plan, therefore, is not to provide a blueprint for a structure that is to be built. This is in stark contrast to the two other places in the Hebrew Bible where someone is shown a heavenly vision of sacred space and given a "plan" (*tavnit*, תבנית) and instructions to go and "build" (*banah*, בנה) it.

Exodus 25:8-9 Instructor's Translation

⁸ Let them **make a sacred space** for me, so that I may dwell among them. ⁹ According to all that I am going to make you see, according to the **pattern** (תבנית) of the tabernacle and the **pattern** (תבנית) of all its furniture, just so you will make it.

1 Chronicles 28:10-12 NASB*

¹⁰ "Consider now, for the LORD has chosen you to build (בנה) a house for the sanctuary; be courageous and act." ¹¹ Then David gave to his son Solomon the **pattern** (תבנית) of the porch of the temple, its buildings, its storehouses, its upper rooms, its inner rooms and the room for the mercy seat; ¹² and the **pattern** (תבנית) of all that he had in mind, for the courts of the house of the LORD, and for all the surrounding rooms, for the storehouses of the house of God and for the storehouses of the dedicated things ...

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

"The informed Israelite reader would expect Ezekiel's vision to be a *tabnit* ("building plan") ... but instead 43:10 speaks of a *toknit* ("proportion"). That Ezekiel has viewed a detailed pattern is confirmed by several appearances of the term *tsura'* ("form, design") in verse 11, so why is Ezekiel 40-48 avoiding the term *tabnit*, while also punning on it with the word *toknit*? Based on the precedents in Exodus 25 and 1 Chronicles 28, recipients of a *tabnit* have actual shrines to build. But Ezekiel's literary temple will not, and cannot be built by humans. The term "form" (*tsura'*) in 43:11 stresses that Ezekiel's temple is, instead, an ideal form ... he has seen not a mere building plan, but the perfect proportions of a real divine archetype."

Cook, Stephen L. (2018). [*Ezekiel 38-48: A New Translation with Introduction and Commentary*](#). Yale University Press. 185.

"The genre of Ezekiel 40-48 is territorial rhetoric ... a deliberate effort to define space, communicate boundaries, and control access to that space ... The rhetorical purpose of the guided tour is to measure the proportion of the house of Yahweh, not to provide a building plan for the temple. The dimensions given are two-dimensional and define spaces rather than structures. This explains the omission of vertical dimensions for almost all of the structures. The three concentric spaces are the House of Yahweh, the Portion, and the Land of Israel ... with the square altar at the concentric center of all these spaces."

Stevenson, Kalinda Rose (1996). [*The Vision of Transformation: The Territorial Rhetoric of Ezekiel 40-48*](#). Scholars Press. 35-36.

"If Ezekiel 40-48 do not provide a construction blueprint for the post-exilic temple, is this temple intended to be only a literary creation, a symbol for the universal presence of God? ... What would be the rhetorical purpose of producing a text in the Babylonian exile which organizes post-exilic Israel around a temple if

Ezekiel didn't expect the returned Israel to have a temple? I find it incomprehensible that Ezekiel could imagine a society without a temple at the symbolic center of the society. Rather than a choice between a building plan or a symbolic metaphor, there is a third option: it is territorial rhetoric ... This text calls for radical social change, by reorganizing Israel's entire geography around Yahweh's presence. Every space that was distorted and abused by Israel's priests and kings has been reshaped and made subordinate to Yahweh's presence in the land."

Adapted quotes from Stevenson, Kalinda Rose (1996). [*The Vision of Transformation: The Territorial Rhetoric of Ezekiel 40-48*](#). Scholars Press. 151-153.

A Blueprint for the Third Temple?

At only one point are any vertical dimensions given (the height of the outer wall in [Ezek. 40:2](#)). Besides that, only horizontal measurements are offered, making chapters 40-42 completely inadequate as an actual blueprint. There is no attempt at being comprehensive in detail, and all kinds of crucial measurements are missing (e.g., the "thirty chambers" in [Ezek. 40:17-18](#) are not described at all, yet they form a crucial part of the courtyard design). This underscores that the rhetorical effect of these chapters is not to offer a building plan, but rather (1) communicate the divine ideals through the design shape of a new sacred space and (2) to offer a prophetic message of exhortation and hope ([Ezek. 43:7-12](#)) that will bring shame and repentance ([Ezek 43:8-10](#)). Any details that do not accord with this purpose are ignored.

"Ezekiel was told to convey to the exiles all that he had seen, especially the symmetrical measurements, but the express purpose of that information was to induce shame (43:10-11). In other words, the purpose of Ezekiel's vision was not to provide guidance as to how the temple was to be rebuilt, but to provide reassurance of the hope that it would be rebuilt. Nowhere is there any explicit command that they were actually to build what Ezekiel described ... in contrast to the instructions for the original tabernacle in the wilderness ... In Ezekiel's account there is no word at all of any human participation in the planning or building of the whole complex; it is simply presented to him as a divine fait accompli in the 'virtual reality' of his vision."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 338.

Shame and Self-Knowledge

In stark contrast, Ezekiel is not shown the ideal temple in order to launch a new building program. Rather, the message communicated by the "proportion, design, and form" is a continuation of Ezekiel's prophetic critique of Israel's history. The perfect design is aimed at bringing his exilic audience to awareness of their guilt so they can see how their corruption of the temple led to its destruction and their isolation in exile.

This has been a stated goal for Ezekiel throughout his entire book, to bring a shameless people who are oblivious and resistant to acknowledge their own role in the disaster of 586 B.C.E. Even Ezekiel's restoration oracles highlight this theme.

Ezekiel 6:9 NASB

Then **those of you who escape will remember me among the nations** to which they will be carried captive, how I have been hurt by their adulterous hearts which turned away from me, and by their eyes which

played the harlot after their idols; and **they will loathe themselves** in their own sight for the evils which they have committed, for all their abominations.

Ezekiel 16:53-54 NASB

⁵³ Nevertheless, I will restore their captivity, the captivity of Sodom and her daughters, the captivity of Samaria and her daughters, and along with them your own captivity, ⁵⁴ **in order that you may bear your humiliation and feel ashamed for all that you have done** when you become a consolation to them.

Ezekiel 16:60-63 NASB

⁶⁰ “Nevertheless, I will remember my covenant with you in the days of your youth, and I will establish an everlasting covenant with you. ⁶¹ **Then you will remember your ways and be ashamed** when you receive your sisters, both your older and your younger; and I will give them to you as daughters, but not because of your covenant. ⁶² Thus I will establish my covenant with you, and you shall know that I am the LORD, ⁶³ **so that you may remember and be ashamed** and never open your mouth anymore because of your humiliation, when I have forgiven you for all that you have done,” the Lord God declares.

Ezekiel 20:42-43 NASB

⁴² And you will know that I am the LORD, when I bring you into the land of Israel, into the land which I swore to give to your forefathers. ⁴³ **There you will remember your ways** and all your deeds with which you have defiled yourselves; **and you will loathe yourselves in your own sight** for all the evil things that you have done.

Ezekiel 36:30-32 NASB

³⁰ “I will multiply the fruit of the tree and the produce of the field, so that you will not receive again the disgrace of famine among the nations. ³¹ **Then you will remember your evil ways** and your deeds that were not good, and **you will loathe yourselves** in your own sight for your iniquities and your abominations. ³² I am not doing this for your sake,” declares the Lord God, “let it be known to you. Be ashamed and confounded for your ways, O house of Israel!”

For Ezekiel, there is a crucial connection between genuine self-knowledge before God and shame, in the sense of an honest awareness of one's shortcomings. From the beginning, Ezekiel has faced an audience that shows no self-awareness of their responsibility for the disaster of Jerusalem's fall. Ezekiel shared many parables and visions to convince his audience of their contributing role. Now Ezekiel shares a vision of the ideal temple to show them just how much the Jerusalem temple's design reflected a corruption of God's honor, holiness, and covenant relationship ideals.

For Ezekiel, the shame that Israel has experienced is the public shame of defeat by enemies and exile from their homeland. These are examples of “public humiliation” or “reproach” (בּוֹשׁ, כלמה), which lower the honor and social status of a person. Ezekiel mentions this kind of shame experienced by his generation of Israelites, but he also highlights a more interior, personal sense of remorse and guilt (קוֹט). Ezekiel uses both of these word groups to accomplish a significant goal: to awaken the Israelites to a healthy sense of their own failures, so they can relate to Yahweh appropriately from a place of honest self-knowledge and a dependence upon divine mercy.

“The people, before their deliverance, are apparently unable to feel shame, that is, they do not have an acute sense of themselves and their actions as others see them or as God sees them, and in Ezekiel’s estimation this is a moral failing in their characters ... The capacity to remember their actions as loathsome, to possess such devastating clarity of self-perception is the equivalent of a new moral self capable of making accurate moral assessments ... For Ezekiel shame is not an inherent part of Israel’s identity, a ‘given’ of their human condition ... the very capacity to experience shame constitutes a salvific act by Yahweh—it is a gift from God. It strips the people of their delusions about themselves as their old-self disintegrates, paving the way for a new identity shaped by a new self-knowledge, to see themselves as Yahweh sees them, and thus opening the way to a restored relationship.”

Lapsley, Jacqueline (2000). “Shame and Self-Knowledge in Ezekiel: The Positive Role of Shame in Ezekiel’s View of the Moral Self.” *The Book of Ezekiel*. 156-159.

The Great Altar Restored

After Ezekiel’s tour of the temple structure and Yahweh returns, Ezekiel returns to the courtyard and focuses on the most massive feature, the 10 feet tall x 34 feet square altar with stairs leading up to it. After being described, Ezekiel hears of its purification and dedication (Ezek. 43:18-27) to begin its regular use in daily sacrifices.

This passage acts as a climax to the initial temple vision of Ezekiel. After touring the great sacred complex, the seven-day dedication ceremony inaugurates the liturgical operations of the temple (just like the seven-day ceremonies of the tabernacle and temple in Lev. 9-10 and 1 Kgs. 8).

Significance: This passage links back to Ezekiel 20:39-41 where Yahweh promises that his people would one day offer pure and acceptable worship, and so they themselves metaphorically become an offering: “I will accept you as fragrant incense” (Ezek. 20:41). So here, the altar account ends with “then I will accept you” (Ezek. 43:27). This is precisely the metaphor Paul adopts of himself as one of those who “worship by the Spirit of God” (Phil. 3:3) and so himself becomes an offering (Phil. 2:17; Rom. 12:1-2).

Macro Design of Ezekiel 44:1-46:24

Ezekiel 44:1-31

The elevation of the **Zadokite priesthood** from among the Levites

44:1-5

The outer east gate closed as Yahweh’s glory fills the temple

- **44:1-3** Outer east gate closed to everyone but the chief, because Yahweh’s glory went through it
- **44:4** Ezekiel sees Yahweh’s glory in the temple
- **44:5** Ezekiel to observe all the instructions about the temple service, and report them

44:6-16**The Levites are separated as Zadokite priests are elevated**

- **44:6-8** The Levites are excluded from serving as priests because of past offenses
- **44:9-14** The Levites are given general temple responsibilities because of past offenses
- **44:15-16** Zadokite priests elevated because of faithfulness

44:17-31**Seven rules of elevated holiness for Zadokite priests**

- **44:17-19** Rule 1: The sacred clothing of the Zadokite priests
- **44:20-27** Rules 2-6: The sacred life of the Zadokite priests
- **44:28-31** The future inheritance of the priests

45:1-25**The holy and just arrangements of land, offerings, and liturgical time****45:1-8****The land inheritance for priests, Levites, people, and chief**

- **45:1-4** The land inheritance of the Zadokite priests
- **45:5** The land inheritance of the Levites
- **45:6-8** The land inheritance of the people and the chief

45:10-17**Justice in the market and in the temple offerings**

- **45:9-12** Justice in economic weights and measures
- **45:13-15** Just measures for Israel's offerings and sacrifices
- **45:16-17** The chief's sponsorship of Israel's offerings and sacrifices for atonement

45:18-25**The new liturgical year sponsored by the chief**

- **45:18-20** The offerings for the new year's festival (01/01 + 01/07)
- **45:21-24** The offerings for Passover (01/14 + 7 days)
- **45:25** The offerings for Sukkot (07/15 + 7 days)

46:1-24**The liturgical and land-inheritance regulations for **the chief** and the kitchens for priestly and common use**

46:1-15

The liturgical rhythms of the people and the chief

- **46:1-8** Inner east gate closed, only opened only on Sabbaths for the chief's offerings
- **46:9-12** The people's regulated movements in sacred space and the chief's offerings
- **46:13-15** The daily offerings made every morning

46:16-18

The land inheritance of the chief and his sons and the Jubilee

- **46:16** The chief can grant land inheritance to his sons
- **46:17** Land inheritance that the chief gives to his servants is restored at the Jubilee
- **46:18** The chief cannot seize land inheritance from the people

46:19-24

Virtual tour of the sacred rooms for priests and Levites

- **46:19-20** Description of the inner-court kitchen for priests
- **46:21-24** Description of the outer-court kitchens for the people and Levites

Ezekiel 44:1-46:24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 44:1-31

¹ And he made me return by the way of the outer gate of the sanctuary,
the one that faces the east;
and it was closed.

² And Yahweh said to me,
"This gate will be closed;
it will not be opened,
and no person will enter by it,
for Yahweh Elohim of Israel has entered by it;
therefore it will be closed.

³ As for the chief,
he will sit in it as a chief,
to eat bread before Yahweh;
he will enter by way of the porch of the gate,
and will go out by the same way."

⁴ And he brought me by way of the north gate to the front of the house;
and I looked, and behold,
the glory of Yahweh filled the house of Yahweh,

and I fell on my face.

⁵ And Yahweh said to me,
 "Son of a human,
 set your heart,
 and see with your eyes
 and hear with your ears,
 everything that I will say to you,
 about all the statutes of the house of Yahweh,
 and about all its instructions;
 and set your heart,
 on the entrance of the house,
 with all exits of the sacred space.

⁶ You will say to the rebels,
to the house of Israel,
 'Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
 "Enough of all your abominations,
 O house of Israel,
⁷ when you brought in foreigners,
 uncircumcised in heart,
 and uncircumcised in flesh,
 to be in my sacred space,
 so as to profane it, my house,
 when you offered my food,
 the fat and the blood;
 for they violated my covenant;
 in addition to all your abominations!
⁸ And you have not kept charge of my holy things,
 but you have set them to keep charge of my sacred space."

⁹ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
 "Any foreigner,
uncircumcised in heart,
 and uncircumcised in flesh,
 he will not enter my sacred space,
 any foreigners who are among the sons of Israel.

¹⁰ However, the Levites,
 who wandered away from me when Israel wandered away,
 who wandered away from me after their idols,
 they will bear the punishment for their iniquity.

¹¹ And they will be servants in my sacred space,
 appointed at the gates of the house,
 and serving in the house;
 they will slaughter the burnt offering and the sacrifice for the people,
 and they will stand before them to serve them.

¹² Because they served them before their idols,
and they became a stumbling block of iniquity to the house of Israel,
therefore I have lifted my hand on oath against them,"
declares Yahweh Elohim,
"that they will bear the punishment for their iniquity.

¹³ And they will not come near to me,
to serve me as priests,
nor come near to any of my holy things,
to the things that are most holy;
but they will bear their shame,
and also their abominations which they have committed.

¹⁴ Yet I will appoint them as keepers of the keeping of the house,
of all its service,
and of all that will be done in it.

¹⁵ But the Levite priests, **the sons of Zadok**,
who kept charge of my sacred space,
when the sons of Israel wandered away from me,
they will come near to me to minister to me,
and they will stand before me to offer me the fat and the blood,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁶ "They will enter my sacred space;
they will come near to my table to serve me and keep my keeping,

¹⁷ And it will be that when they enter at the gates of the inner court,
they will be clothed with linen garments;
and wool will not be on them,
while they are ministering in the gates of the inner court and in the house.

¹⁸ Linen turbans will be on their heads,
and linen undergarments will be on their loins;
they will not gird themselves with anything that causes sweat.

¹⁹ When they go out into the outer court,
into the outer court to the people,
they will take off their garments in which they have been serving,
and they will rest them in the holy rooms,
and they will put on other garments,
so that they will not transmit holiness to the people with their garments.

²⁰ And they will not shave their heads,
and they will not let their locks grow long;
they will only trim the hair of their heads.

²¹ Nor will any of the priests drink wine,
when they enter the inner court.

²² And they will not marry a widow or a divorced woman,
but will take unmarried women from the seed of the house of Israel,
or a widow who is the widow of a priest.

²³ And, they will teach my people between the holy and the common,
and help them know between the pure and the impure.

²⁴ And in a dispute they stand to judge;
they will judge it according to my justice.
They will also keep my instructions and my statutes in all my appointed feasts,
and they will treat my sabbaths as holy.

²⁵ They will not go to a dead person so as to become impure;
however, for a father or for a mother,
or for a son, or for a daughter,
for a brother, or for a sister who has not had a husband,
they may become impure.

²⁶ After he is purified,
they will count seven days for him,

²⁷ and on the day that he goes into the sacred space,
into the inner court to serve in the sanctuary,
he will bring near his purification offering,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

²⁸ "And it will be their inheritance;
I am their inheritance;
and you will give them no possession in Israel;
I am their possession.

²⁹ They will eat the grain offering, the purification offering and the guilt offering;
and every devoted thing in Israel will be theirs.

³⁰ The first of all the first fruits,
every kind and every contribution of every kind,
everything from all your contributions,
they will be for the priests;
and the first of your dough you will also give to the priest,
to cause a blessing to rest on your house.

³¹ Any dead or torn corpse of any bird or beast,
the priests will not eat.""

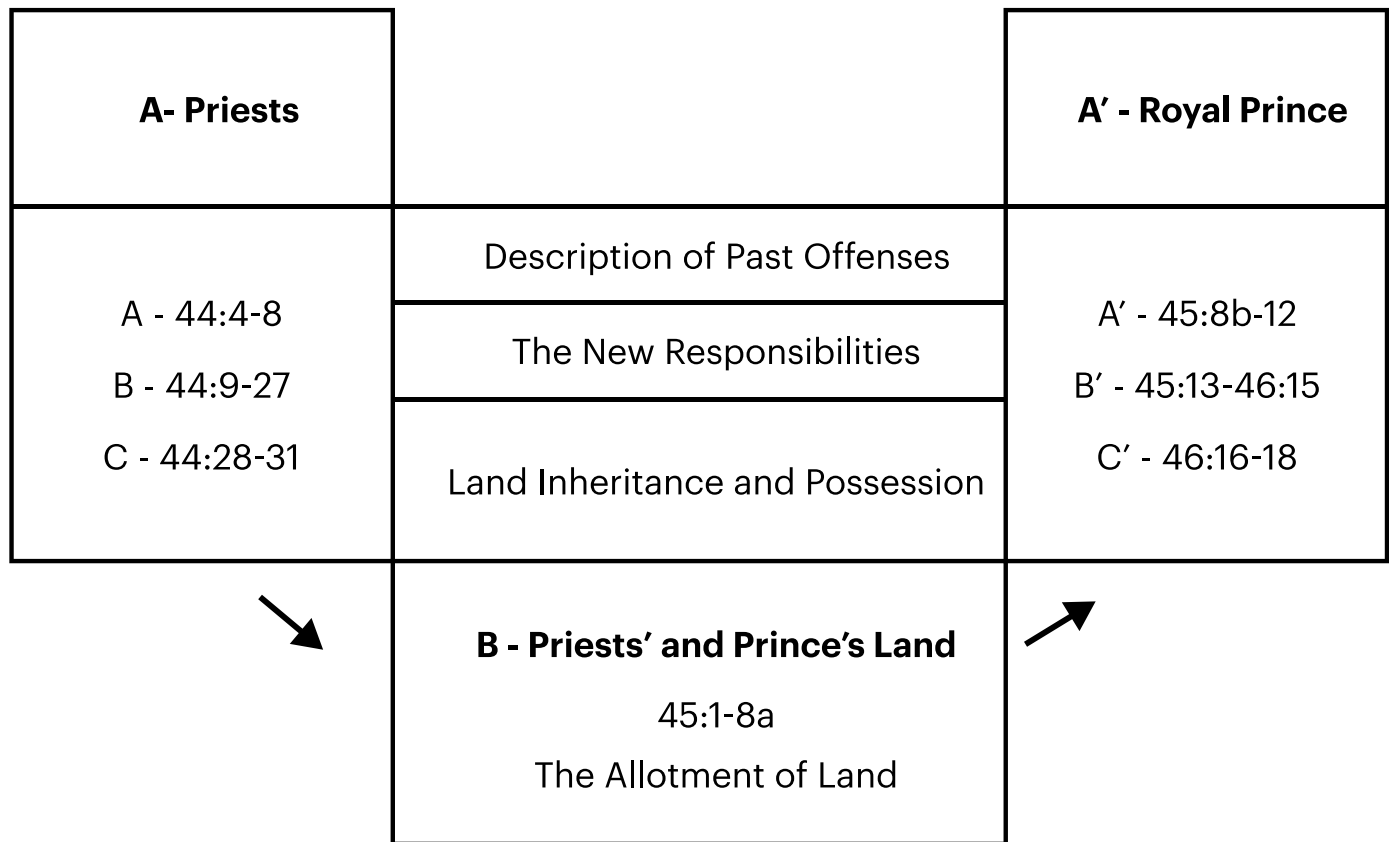
Ezekiel 44:1-31. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Closed Outer East Gate

Yahweh enters the new temple by means of this gate in [Ezekiel 43:1-4](#), marking it as most holy and symbolically off-limits for normal foot traffic, so it is permanently closed. The closure is also significant because this is precisely the gate through which Yahweh left the temple ([10:19](#); [11:1](#), [22-23](#)). Its closure thus represents the permanence of Yahweh's residence among his people.

Restored Worship

This next section, Ezekiel 44:4-46:18, describes the restored worship of Israel in the new temple by focusing on the priesthood and prince of the people. The section has a symmetrical shape focusing on two groups of people who will serve Yahweh in the running of the temple and the land.



Symmetrical Design of Ezekiel 44:4-46:18. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Priesthood Restored to Zadok and Levi

Ezekiel describes the restoration of the Levites to their role in the temple, and restricts the priesthood to the clan of Zadok, a family that came through Aaron's son Eleazar (see 1 Chron. 6:1-8). Zadok remained loyal to David and Solomon and so was elevated as high priest in place of Abiathar, who was from the line of Aaron's son Ithamar that led to Eli (see 2 Sam. 15:25-27; 1 Kgs. 1:8, 39; 2:35).

Ezekiel describes an incident not described anywhere else in the Hebrew Bible where the sons of Zadok remained faithful to Yahweh when the rest of the Levites participated in Israel's idolatry (Ezek. 44:10, 15). And so in the new temple, the Levites are restored to their role (teachers and priests for the people) while the Zadokite priests alone are elevated for their faithfulness (Ezek. 44:15-16). The priests were not to possess wealth in the form of land (Ezek. 45:1-8) but were to live off the offerings of the Israelites, and so remain in a symbolic place of dependence on an obedient Israel.

Significantly, the language of priesthood was adopted in the New Testament to describe Jesus as high priest (Heb. 7-10) and his followers as priests (1 Peter 2:9-10; Rev. 1:6).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 45:1-25

¹ "And when you divide by lot the land for inheritance,
you will offer an allotment to Yahweh,
a holy portion of the land;
the length will be the length of 25,000 cubits,
and the width will be 20,000.
It will be holy within all its boundary round about.

² Out of this there will be for the holy place a square round about,
five hundred by five hundred cubits,
and fifty cubits for its open space round about.

³ From this area you will measure a length of 25,000 cubits and a width of 10,000 cubits;
and in it will be the sacred space, the most holy place.

⁴ It will be the holy portion of the land;
it will be for the priests, the servants of the sacred space,
who come near to serve Yahweh,
and it will be a place for their houses,
and a holy place for the sacred space.

⁵ An area 25,000 cubits in length and 10,000 in width,
it will be for the Levites, the servants of the house,
and for their possession cities to dwell in.

⁶ You will give the city possession of an area 5,000 cubits wide and 25,000 cubits long,
next to the allotment of the holy portion;
it will be for the whole house of Israel.

⁷ The chief will have land on either side of the holy allotment and the property of the city,
next to the holy allotment and the property of the city,
on the west side toward the west,
and on the east side toward the east,
and in length comparable to one of the portions,
from the west border to the east border.

⁸ This will be his land for a possession in Israel;
so my chiefs will no longer oppress my people,
but they will give the rest of the land to the house of Israel according to their tribes."

⁹ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"Enough, you chiefs of Israel;
put away violence and destruction,
and practice justice and righteousness.
Stop the evictions of my people,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁰ "You will have just balances,
a just ephah and a just bath.

¹¹ The ephah and the bath will be the same quantity,
so that the bath will contain a tenth of a homer,
and the ephah a tenth of a homer;
their standard will be according to the homer.

¹² The shekel will be twenty gerahs;
twenty shekels, twenty-five shekels,
and fifteen shekels will be your maneh.

¹³ This is the offering that you will offer:
a sixth of an ephah from a homer of wheat;
a sixth of an ephah from a homer of barley;

¹⁴ and the prescribed portion of oil,
namely, the bath of oil,
a tenth of a bath from each kor,
which is ten baths or a homer,
for ten baths are a homer;

¹⁵ and one sheep from each flock of two hundred from the watering places of Israel,
for a grain offering, for a burnt offering and for peace offerings,
to make atonement for them,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

¹⁶ "For all the people of the land,
this will be the offering,
for the chief in Israel.

¹⁷ It will be on the chief to provide the burnt offerings, the grain offerings and the drink offerings,
at the feasts, on the new moons and on the sabbaths, at all the appointed feasts of the house of Israel;
he will provide the sin offering, the grain offering, the burnt offering and the peace offerings,
to make atonement for the house of Israel."

¹⁸ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
"In the first month,
on the first of the month,
you will take a young bull without blemish,
and you will purify the sacred space.

¹⁹ The priest will take some of the blood from the purification offering,
and he will put it on the door posts of the house,
on the four corners of the ledge of the altar,
and on the posts of the gate of the inner court.

²⁰ Thus you will do on the seventh day of the month,
for everyone who goes astray or is ignorant;
so you will make atonement for the house.

²¹ In the first month,
on the fourteenth day of the month,
you will have the Passover,
a feast of seven days;
unleavened bread will be eaten.

²² On that day the chief will provide
for himself and for all the people of the land,
a bull for a sin offering.

²³ During the seven days of the feast he will provide as a burnt offering to Yahweh,
seven bulls and seven rams without blemish,
on every day of the seven days,
and a male goat daily for a purification offering.

²⁴ He will provide as a grain offering,
an ephah with a bull,
an ephah with a ram,
and a hin of oil with an ephah.

²⁵ In the seventh month,
on the fifteenth day of the month, at the feast,
he will provide like this for seven days,
like the purification offering, the burnt offering, the grain offering and the oil.”

Ezekiel 45:1-25. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Land Inheritance of the Priests and Royal Chief

Ezekiel uses the language of a firstfruits offerings (see [Num. 15:19-20](#)) to describe a section of land that the Israelites will offer to Yahweh (8mi. x 6.5mi.) in their new inheritance, just as the Levites had their own cities before (48 total, 6 as cities of refuge, see Num. 35).

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 46:1-24

¹ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
“The gate of the inner court facing east,
it will be shut the six days of work;
but on the day of the Sabbath it will be opened,
and on the day of the new moon it will be opened.

² And the prince will enter by way of the porch of the gate from outside,
and he will stand by the doorpost of the gate,
and the priests will perform his ascension offering and his peace offerings,
and he will worship at the threshold of the gate
and then he will go out;
and the gate will not be shut until the evening.

³ And the people of the land will worship,
at the doorway of that gate,
on the sabbaths and on the new moons,
before the face of Yahweh.

⁴ And the burnt offering which the prince will bring near to Yahweh on the sabbath day,
six lambs without blemish,

and a ram without blemish;

⁵ and the grain offering will be an ephah with the ram,
and the grain offering with the lambs as much as he is able to give,
and a hin of oil with an ephah.

⁶ And on the day of the new moon a young bull without blemish,
and six lambs and a ram,
they will be without blemish.

⁷ And an ephah with the bull,
and an ephah with the ram,
he will provide as a grain offering;
and with the lambs as much as he is able,
and a hin of oil with an ephah.

⁸ When the prince enters,
he will enter by way of the porch of the gate,
and by the same way he will go out.

⁹ And when the people of the land come before the face Yahweh at the appointed feasts,
the one who enters by way of the north gate to worship,
they will go out by way of the south gate;
and the one who enters by way of the south gate,
they will go out by way of the north gate.
No one will return by way of the gate by which they entered,
but they will go straight out.

¹⁰ And the chief in their midst, when they go in, he will go in;
and when they go out, he will go out.

¹¹ At the festivals and the appointed feasts there will be a grain offering;
an ephah with a bull and an ephah with a ram,
and with the lambs as much as one is able to give,
and a hin of oil with an ephah.

¹² And when the chief provides a freewill offering,
an ascension offering, or peace offerings as a freewill offering to Yahweh,
the gate facing east will be opened for him,
and he will perform his ascension offering and his peace offerings,
just as he does on the sabbath day.
Then he will go out,
and the gate will be shut after he goes out.

¹³ And a lamb, one year old without blemish,
you will perform as an ascension offering to Yahweh each day;
morning by morning you will perform it.

¹⁴ And a grain offering you will perform with it morning by morning,
a sixth of an ephah,
and a third of a hin of oil to moisten the fine flour,
a grain offering to Yahweh,
a perpetual statute, continually.

¹⁵ And they will perform the lamb, the grain offering and the oil,

morning by morning,
for a continual ascension offering.”

- ¹⁶ Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
“If the chief gives a gift out of his inheritance to any of his sons,
it will belong to his sons;
it is their possession by inheritance.
¹⁷ And if he gives a gift from his inheritance to one of his servants,
it will be his until the year of liberation;
then it will return to the chief.
His inheritance will be only his sons’;
it will belong to them.
¹⁸ The chief will not take from the people’s inheritance,
so as to oppress them out of their possession;
he will give his sons inheritance from his own possession,
so that My people will not be scattered, each from his possession.”

- ¹⁹ And he brought me through the entrance, which was at the side of the gate,
into the holy chambers for the priests, which faced north;
and look, there was a place at the extreme rear toward the west,
²⁰ and he said to me,
“This is the place where the priests will boil the guilt offering and the sin offering,
where they will bake the grain offering,
in order that they may not bring them out into the outer court to transmit holiness to the people.”
²¹ And he brought me out into the outer court,
and he led me across to the four corners of the court;
and behold, in every corner of the court there was a smaller court.
²² In the four corners of the court there were courts for rising smoke,
forty cubits long and thirty wide;
these four in the corners were the same size.
²³ There was a row of masonry round about in them,
around the four of them,
and boiling places were made under the rows round about.
²⁴ Then he said to me,
“These are houses of the cooking fires,
where the servants of the house will cook the sacrifices of the people.”

Ezekiel 46:1-24. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The Chief’s Role in the Sacrificial Liturgies

In [Ezekiel 46:1-15](#), recalling the perpetually closed east gate by which Yahweh’s glory entered into the temple ([Ezek. 43:1-6](#), [44:1-3](#)), we now learn that the chief will sit in that gate on the Sabbath and new month days and sponsor sacrifices on behalf of the people.

The chief alone can enter and exit the east gate, but he may not pass through it. Rather, he can sit in the porch of the gate and make his offerings.

The chief plays a combined role of a king and priest, offering sacrifices on behalf of the people who are gathered around the east gate outside. But the chief's role is also minimized in comparison to Israel's past kings, like Solomon who offered the sacrifices on the day of the temple's inauguration (see 1 Kgs. 8). Here, the chief plays a downsized role that fits within Ezekiel's larger program to correct the past abuses of Israel's kings who claimed a more aggrandized role for themselves than they should have.

The Chief's Limited Property Rights

In Ezek. 46:16-18, Ezekiel recalls the injustice of Israel's kings in seizing ancestral lands from the tribes (e.g., Ahab and Naboth's vineyard, 1 Kgs. 21) and in bending economic policies in their favor (see Amos 8:5-6; Hos. 12:7; Mic. 6:10-11).

Ezekiel specifically targets the practice of "political gifts" of land to people outside his family and tribe (Ezek. 46:17). The king cannot appropriate the land from other tribes and then give it as a political gift to further his own agenda. Rather, the original land allotment stands perpetually. This is grounded in the concept of the land made clear in the Jubilee guidelines of Leviticus 25: The land belongs to Yahweh, and he gives it as a gift to his servants to be perpetually restored every 7x7 Jubilee cycle.

Back to the Rooms for the Priests

Ezekiel 46:19-24 picks up the narrative of Ezekiel's vision from 44:1-4. Since that passage, there have been a series of divine speeches inserted into the narrative (marked by speech formula at 44:6; 45:18; 46:1, 16), and here the narrative resumes.

One of the last places in the heavenly temple that Ezekiel is shown before Yahweh's glory enters the temple are the rooms (לשכות) where the priests sit to eat the holy sacrificial meats that remain from Israel's offerings (Ezek. 42:13-14). So here, near the end of the central literary unit in Ezekiel's vision, similar rooms are described. These are the special places where Israel's priests can cook and eat the holy meat from the offerings so as not to transmit holiness to the outer courts where the people are.

What's Up With the "Chief" in Ezekiel 45-46?

In his vision of the restored temple, Ezekiel envisions a role for a royal leader of the tribes of Israel, but as with everything in this vision, his role is heavily modified and diminished from the authority and role of the past kings of Judah.

The Title "Chief" Versus "King"

Ezekiel saves the word "king" (Heb. *melek* / מֶלֶךְ) to refer to Judah's failed kings of the past (Ezek. 1:2, 17:12) or to the rulers of non-Israelite nations (Babylon in 19:9; Tyre in 28:12; Egypt in 29:2). Only one time does he refer to the future messianic seed of David as a "king" (in Ezek. 37:22-24). Ezekiel's most consistent term for the future royal leader of the restored Israel is "chief" (*nasi'* / נָשִׂיא).

“Chief” is an older title used to describe the tribal leaders. Abraham is called a *nasi’* by the Hittites (Gen. 23:6), and Ishmael's descendants who are tribal leaders are called *nasi’* (Gen. 25:16).

In the days before Israel's monarchy, their tribal leaders were called “chiefs” (see Exod. 16:22, 34:31).

In the arrangement of the twelve tribal camps around the tabernacle, the title “chief” is used more (62x in Numbers 1-36) than anywhere else in the Hebrew Bible, aside from Ezekiel 40-48 (where it's used 37x).

The Modified Role of the “Chief”

The following is a profile of the chief's role in Ezekiel 40-48 adapted from Block, Daniel (2010).

“Transformation of Royal Ideology in Ezekiel.” 40-41.

- While the eastern out gate is forever closed to human traffic, the chief alone can sit in the gate house to eat his sacrificial meals before Yahweh (Ezek. 44:1-3). After consuming the offerings, he has to leave out the gate and it is shut behind him.
- The chief is given a special territory, separate from the other tribes, made of two pieces of land to the east and west of the sacred square at the center of the sacred “reserve” (Ezek. 45:7-9, 48:21).
- The chief is the sponsor of all the animals and food for the sacrifices offered on behalf of his family and all the tribes (Ezek. 45:21-25).
- On weekly Sabbaths and new moon dates, the chief stands in the inner court watching the priests present offerings on his behalf (Ezek. 46:1-7, 12).
- The chief can give his granted property to his sons as a family possession, but he cannot confiscate anyone else's land (Ezek. 46:18). And if he gives some of his family land to anyone outside the royal house, it returns to his family in the Jubilee (Ezek. 46:17).

Ezekiel's chief is a highly diminished figure in the restoration, and we can see elements of critique of past misbehavior that is being regulated and prevented. The chief is a civil representative of the tribes who facilitates the temple liturgy alongside the Zadokite priesthood. Together, they function as a royal-priesthood. But their offices are kept separate so as to avoid the violations of Israel's past kings.

The chief is subordinate to the holiness of God and the liturgy; he is not responsible for the operations of the temple. The chief does not build the temple, design the worship, or appoint the priests (as Israel's kings often did).

The Davidic Chief/King of Chapters 34 and 37 and the Chief of Chapters 40–48

There are several views regarding the relationship between the Davidic chief/king of Ezekiel 34 and 37 to the chief of chapters 40-48.

View 1: They Are Not the Same Figure

“The term *nasi’* describes a leader in a more general sense, not necessarily with any connotation of royalty ... There seems to be no connection to the messianic portrayal of a new David that we saw in chapters 34 and 37. The figure in chapters 40-48 appears in the role of patron and provider for the religious ceremonies

taking place in the temple. There is no exaltation of his status or any separate privileges. Much more is made of his responsibilities than of his status ... So this does not appear to be a messianic figure ruling in righteousness. This is a very human figure participating in the rituals, offering sacrifices for his own sins (46:1-7), and susceptible to the perennial temptations that surround those in authority (45:9-10; 46:18).” Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 353-354.

View 2: They Are the Same Figure Portraying Different Roles

The prince in these visions plays a subordinate role to Yahweh and the priesthood, and he fulfills all the ideals of the original Davidic commission that Judah’s kings never fully realized.

“In Ezekiel’s mind, the kings of Israel, specifically David and his descendants, were Yahweh’s specially chosen agents appointed to govern his people in his place and thereby secure their well-being. The king’s primary role was to represent Yahweh by embodying covenant righteousness in providing security for the people and their land and facilitating the worship of Yahweh in the temple. But in Ezekiel’s mind, the ideal and reality of the history of Israel’s monarchy were miles apart and so his vision of the coming messianic king portrays him in a subordinate role to Yahweh (chs. 34, 37) and a subordinate role in facilitating the worship of Yahweh as the prince in chs. 40-48.”

Block, Daniel (2010). “Transformation of Royal Ideology in Ezekiel.”

View 3: Ezekiel's "Chief" Fits in a Larger Messianic Mosaic

Ezekiel’s “chief” is a composite portrait that emerges from the many images of the messianic role in the various parts of the Bible. The final framers of the TaNaK did not create a homogeneous mosaic, but they allowed all the individual pictures to stand alongside each other in their diversity.

Sometimes the focus is on the expectation of a coming royal Davidic king who will rule a reunited Israel and the nations in justice and righteousness and rebuild a new temple: [Genesis 49:8-12](#); [Numbers 24:17](#) [2 Samuel 7](#); [Isaiah 9:1-6](#), [11:1-15](#); [Psalms 2](#), [72](#), [110](#), [132](#).

Sometimes the focus is on an ideal priest who will mediate perfectly between God and his people: Jethro in [Exodus 18](#), the messianic high priest in [Exodus 28](#), Moses the functional high priest in [Exodus 32-34](#), and the faithful high priest in [1 Samuel 1-2](#).

Sometimes the focus is on a coming royal priest who will rejoin the offices of priest and king in one person: Melchizedek in [Genesis 14:18-20](#), David as royal priest in [2 Samuel 6-7](#), and David as king and temple builder in [1 Chronicles 17-29](#).

Sometimes the focus is on the two offices of king and priest operating together in harmony in the restored Israel: Ezekiel 40-48, [Zechariah 4](#) and [6](#).

In this discussion, it’s important that we honor the stated goals of Ezekiel’s temple vision in [Ezekiel 43:1-11](#) within its own context.

Very often, Jewish and Christian readers adapt Ezekiel’s vision as they integrate it into a larger mosaic of “restored temple” imagery from the prophets and Psalms ([Isa. 2:1-4](#); [Joel 3](#); [Zech. 2](#); etc.). Such adaptation

usually forces Ezekiel's vision into the categories of modern Christian debates of eschatology (millennial temple, end-times temple, etc.). The problem is these categories are not native to the Hebrew Bible, so they end up distorting our vision of each text on its own terms.

The portrait of the "chief" in Ezekiel 44-46 is a great example. Ezekiel's vision is a critique of the past by means of holding up an ideal, and to accomplish that goal the Davidic heir is never called "king" but only "chief," the ancient name of Israel's first tribal leaders. The "chief" is a king who has been very much downgraded from the self-aggrandizing habits of Israel's past rulers. In Ezekiel 44-46, he is subservient to the priests and to Yahweh.

Reflection Question

What is the purpose of Ezekiel's temple vision?